I have harboured this project for forty years. During these years, I have tracked VOC—a search that has shaped my vocation as a historian, my life as a social being and my conscience as an individual. I have tracked records in libraries and archives across India and in the UK, France, Ireland, the USA and Sri Lanka. I have met scores of people who have helped with records and information. They have also taught me what life is.

Four decades is a long time, and it is impossible to remember all the good souls who assisted a greenhorn historian obsessed with a long-lost hero.

My search first began in Maraimalai Adigal Library, Chennai, in 1981—when I was a schoolboy dressed in shorts. It was there that I saw the only known original copy of an SSNCo prospectus. The handwritten letters of VOC and the volumes of *Vivekabhanu* housed there were my first introduction to what historians call primary material. Some years later, it was my fortune to be incharge of the very same library (1987–90), the single greatest education of my life. I am thankful to the late R. Muthukumaraswamy for this opportunity.

In 1981, I first met V.O.C. Subramaniam (1925–91), VOC's third son. Apart from blessing my efforts, he was warmly supportive of my work until he passed away a decade later.

Turned away from its gates as a schoolboy, in 1984, during my first year in college, I entered the musty corridors of the Tamilnadu Archives (TNA). Its rich collection, primarily of the proceedings of the Government of Madras, forms the cornerstone of this study. Over the years, I have repeatedly cast my net into this sea of records and have always emerged with a rich catch. I recall, too, the exciting discussions that I had with fellow scholars. I would especially like to recall conversations with C.S. Subramanyam, a founding member of the Communist Party of India in Tamilnadu who was then researching on M.P.T. Acharya, N. Rajendran, who went on to publish a monograph on the Swadeshi movement in Tamilnadu and the late D. Veeraraghavan who worked on his landmark history of the working class movement in Madras.

In 1985, I made my first trip to New Delhi. For a sophomoric student, it was not easy to obtain permission to work in the Nehru Memorial Museum